

By Nandini Vaish

Ajay Kaul is hungry for time. The 45-year-old CEO of Jubilant FoodWorks, the master franchise for Domino's Pizza in India, looks constantly at his watch, the ticking minutes whetting his appetite. And it figures: Kaul's pizzas have to reach customers in 30 minutes and he wants to open more than 60 new outlets every year.

As he launched Jubilant's 300th outlet in Delhi's Pitampura last month, Patrick Doyle, the global CEO of Domino's Pizza Inc, said, "Our teams in India and Louisiana, USA, are two of the largest and best franchisees." At a growth rate of nearly 42 per cent for the last five years, the company's India operations are its fastest in the world.

Doyle's and Kaul's appetite for India is shared by competitors. Whether it is multinational chains like McDonald's, Pizza Hut, KFC or home-grown ones like Sagar Ratna, Yo! China, Haldiram's, Bikanervala or Nirula's, they are all racing to open new restaurants. McDonald's, which had 20 outlets in India till 2002, has 187 today. It plans to open 200 more over five years with an investment of Rs 500 crore. Yum! Restaurants, owner of the KFC and Pizza Hut brands, plans to add 15 and 20 outlets respectively. The story is repeated across the road with Nirula's looking to add 120 new points of presence, Sagar Ratna 35 new outlets by December and Delhi-based Bikanervala and Haldiram's four-five new outlets every year. Even traditional entities like the Bangalore-based MTR Restaurant and the Chennai-based Murugan Idli Shop (MIS) are looking at Delhi and Mumbai, "for the first time in 80 years", according to Hemamalini Maiya, managing partner, MTR Restaurants.

The temptation was just too hard to resist. Maiya says expanding beyond Bangalore is something her late father (who started the restaurant) would never have approved of, but that makes clear business sense. After all, says Gaurav Marya, president,



	Domino's	McDonald's	Pizza Hut*	KFC
Number of outlets	300	187	160	74
Presence across cities	70	44	37	14
Outlets by 2012	400-430	219	200	230
Presence across cities by 2012	95	54	40	35-40

Taste of GROWTH

As increasing affluence puts the Indian fast food sector in the fast lane, home-grown